

Multilingualism is a better way to teaching, learning, and assessment in countries with different languages. It helps to build knowledge, empowers students, and improves educational outcomes. In South Africa, where students speak multiple languages, relying on only one language in education is both limiting and unfair. Therefore, multilingualism should be adopted to create a more inclusive and effective education system.

Firstly, multilingualism will help students understand academic content. Learners will be able to use languages that they know to process information more effectively. Traditional approaches often assume that one language, usually English, is sufficient for learning. However, article says that multilingual students benefit more when they are allowed to use their full linguistic repertoire through practices such as translanguaging (Mbiri-Hungwe, 2023: 1). This approach allows students to interpret, discuss, and express ideas using familiar languages, leading to deeper comprehension. In this way, language becomes a resource rather than a barrier to learning.

Secondly, multilingualism promotes inclusion and supports students' confidence. When learners' home languages are not part of learning and teaching, they may not understand the content being taught. Studies indicate that students who are taught in unfamiliar languages often fail to engage and may become passive in the learning process (Viriri & Ndimande-Hlongwa, 2023: 7). In contrast, whenever different languages are recognized and used in teaching, students feel valued and included. This inclusive environment strengthens their confidence and encourages active participation, which is essential for academic success.

Furthermore, multilingualism improves educational outcomes, particularly in assessment. Using English as the only language of assessment can be a problem to students who are not fluent in it. They may struggle to understand questions or express their answers clearly, even when they understand the content. Research highlights that using indigenous languages in assessment can improve fairness and allow students to demonstrate their full potential (Viriri & Ndimande-Hlongwa, 2023: 1). Additionally, multilingual teaching strategies have been shown to improve literacy development and comprehension, as learners are able to connect new knowledge with their existing linguistic and cognitive resources (Carrim & Nkomo, 2023: 195).

In conclusion, multilingualism is a valuable and necessary approach in linguistically diverse countries. It enhances understanding, promotes inclusion, and improves academic performance. Education systems that rely on a single dominant language risk disadvantaging many learners. Therefore, adopting multilingual approaches in teaching, learning, and assessment is essential for creating a fair, inclusive, and effective education system.